



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

EMERGENCY response leader Jack Oelfke walks past burned and not-burned areas of Santa Rosa Island.

Saving pristine habitat after wildfire

Officials and scientists assess damage on Santa Rosa Island, a rare ecological oasis.

By GRACE TOOHEY

SANTA ROSA ISLAND, Calif. — Just steps above a white sand beach with calm, turquoise waves, the effects of the largest fire in Channel Islands National Park history are particularly stark: Fields of island grasses and chaparral have been reduced to ash, the earth singed to black. Hillsides are colored a rusty red from desperate retardant drops.

And when the wind whips, the air reeks of a potent campfire — but no campers are around.

It's been just days since firefighters reached 100% containment of the 18,379-acre blaze that scorched about one-third of the island and damaged many prized resources, including rare Torrey pines.

The remote island — some 30 miles southwest of Santa Barbara — is typically quiet, yet the stillness feels almost heavy.

The 150 firefighters who responded to the blaze have returned to the mainland, and the island remains closed to the public. The only humans who remain are a team of about a dozen park rangers and Department of the Interior scientists who are working to review the fire damage and understand the scale of the loss.

Their findings will serve [See Santa Rosa, A6]

Pratt's disaffected base confronts the future

By Jenny Jarvie

When Republican Spencer Pratt burst into Los Angeles politics, venting a torrent of online fury against Mayor Karen Bass' handling of the Palisades fire, he pitched his mayoral campaign as a full-bore challenge to L.A.'s political status quo.

The former reality TV star, who lost his home in the blaze, started as a long shot but emerged as a national story, with the ability to harvest social media attention, rally a base and dominate the news cycle.

But in a city overwhelmingly Democratic, where Republicans make up just 15% of registered voters, even some of his supporters wondered how far he could rise. In the end, voters selected Bass, a Democratic centrist, and democratic socialist City Councilmember Nithya Raman, who ran to Bass' left, to face off in the runoff.

Still, for many of the 200,000 Angelenos who voted for Pratt, his brash, social media-fueled campaign was not just a long exercise in trolling. Pratt gave voice to their discontent with the system of one-party rule and said things they too often felt uncomfortable saying.

And now, they face a difficult choice of whom to support in November.

"I know a lot of people who are disappointed," said Meghan Daum, an L.A. writer and podcaster and former Los Angeles Times columnist who endorsed Pratt. "They are saying, 'OK, now what? What can we do?'"

While Pratt did not make the runoff, political experts said his candidacy tapped into Angelenos' dissatisfaction with the Democratic establishment and resonated with a sizable number of Angelenos who are rarely represented in L.A. politics.

"He identified a previously invisible level of anger and frustration," Dan Schnur, a longtime politics professor at USC, UC Berkeley and Pepperdine University, said of Pratt. "The question going forward is whether he, or someone else, can shape that raw emotion into a movement."

Pratt has yet to put out a statement conceding the race or contesting the results. As a stream of Republicans, including President Trump, made unfounded allegations of [See Pratt, A7]

Becerra leads two-man poll

Hilton trails far behind in blue state's governor race

By NICOLE NIXON

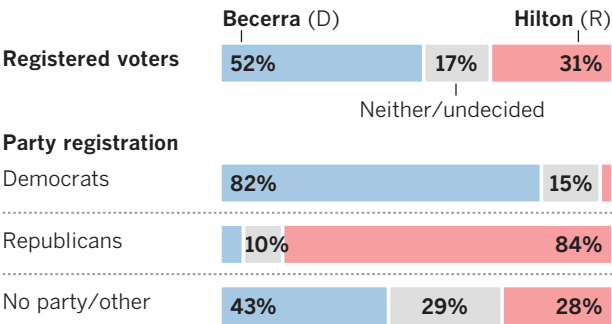
SACRAMENTO — Democrat Xavier Becerra holds a major advantage over Republican Steve Hilton as the race for California governor heads toward the November election, a new poll shows.

The two candidates topped a crowded field of gubernatorial hopefuls in the June 2 primary, earning them the opportunity to face off in the general election.

Among registered voters in the state, 52% supported Becerra in a head-to-head matchup against Hilton, [See Poll, A7]

Going head-to-head

Going into November's gubernatorial election, California registered voters favor Xavier Becerra over Steve Hilton.



LORENA INIGUEZ ELEBEE Los Angeles Times

Fresh strikes and surging prices in new phase of war

U.S. attacks resume as Trump accuses Iran of stringing him along in talks for a peace deal.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — U.S. retaliatory strikes against Iran will continue after its forces shot down an American helicopter, President Trump said Wednesday, accusing the Islamic Republic of stringing him along over months of negotiations to end the war.

The prospect of a renewed U.S. air campaign cast fresh doubt on the viability of a ceasefire between the United States and Iran that has largely held since April, when the two sides reached a tenuous truce, pausing weeks of fighting. Trump's decision to resume attacks comes after an exchange of fire between Israel and Iran threatened to spiral into open war over the weekend.

The Pentagon has presented Trump with options to expand U.S. targets beyond the immediate area around the Strait of Hormuz

to Iranian power plants across the country, an escalation that will open the president up to accusations he is targeting civilian infrastructure, according to a defense official familiar with the matter.

Speaking with reporters in the Oval Office, Trump encouraged the Iranians to accept a framework agreement negotiated between the two sides, and suggested that additional military action might compel Tehran to accept a peace accord.

"We hit them hard yesterday, and we're gonna hit 'em again hard today," Trump said. "And we'll see what happens with the deal. We were really close to a deal, but they keep tapping us along — they keep playing us for suckers."

The president's remarks came a few hours after Trump posted on his social media website that Iran "will have to pay the price" for taking too long in negotiating a peace deal.

When pressed by reporters to elaborate, Trump said he meant that bombing would resume but declined to say whether that would include strikes on Iranian power plants and bridges, a [See War, A4]



DAVID PAUL MORRIS Bloomberg

THE WAR'S economic toll is seen in higher prices for fuel and goods. Above, workers in San Francisco.

Inflation reaches a three-year high

Cost increases are creating headaches for consumers, the Fed and possibly Trump.

By CHRISTOPHER RUGABER

Rising gas prices pushed inflation to its highest level in three years last month, a headache for the Federal Reserve and a potential political challenge for the Trump administration as midterm elections near.

Consumer prices rose 4.2% in May from a year earlier, the Labor Department said Wednesday, up from 3.8% in April and the third straight monthly increase. On a monthly basis, prices rose 0.5% last month, after big gains of 0.6% in April and 0.9% in March.

Prices have now risen faster than wages for several months, pressuring many Americans' finances and causing consumers to take a decidedly dim view of the economy. Families are dipping into savings to maintain their spending, and more people are falling be-

hind on their credit card bills. Large retailers say they have noticed changes in customer behavior, such as buying smaller amounts of gas during visits to the pump.

Inflation is now well above the Federal Reserve's 2% target, which it has surpassed for more than five years. New Fed Chair Kevin Warsh will preside over his first policy meeting next week, when the central bank is expected to keep its key interest rate unchanged. But the Fed also is likely to change the statement it issues after each meeting to remove a suggestion that its next move could be to lower rates. With inflation proving stubborn, financial markets expect that the Fed could instead raise rates by the end of the year.

When the Fed lifts rates, over time it can make mortgages, auto loans, and business borrowing more expensive.

Excluding energy costs, price increases last month were not as dramatic, a sign that sharply higher inflation hasn't yet spread throughout the economy. Should the Iran war end and oil and gas [See Inflation, A11]

Protests rise up ahead of Cup opening

MEXICO CITY — The star-studded opening ceremony for the 2026 World Cup will unfold Thursday afternoon in Mexico City.

The Mexican capital joins Guadalajara as the only cities to host games during three editions of the World Cup. Shakira will headline the pre-match spectacle alongside Mexican music stars Alejandro Fernández and Los Angeles Azules.

Fans who paid thousands of dollars for tickets will then cheer on the Mexican team as it faces South Africa at Azteca Stadium, opening an ambitious tournament co-hosted by three countries.

But in the streets outside the historic stadium where soccer legends Pelé in 1970 and Diego Maradona in 1986

Relatives of the missing among those voicing anger in Mexico

By Eduard Cauch



CRISTOPHER ROGEL BLANQUET Getty Images

POLICE guard the area around Azteca Stadium in Mexico City two days before the World Cup's start.

delivered iconic plays, other voices are rising as loud as the cheers.

Ana Laura Velásquez Delgado, who searched for her son Jesús for nine months until an independent group informed her that it had found his body in a grave alongside 12 other people, is among those who have wept, chanted and shouted in protest during the week leading up to the World Cup. "We've been asking for justice for four years," said Velásquez Delgado, a native of Toluca. She said the depression caused by her son's death led to her husband's recent death.

"If all the money Mexico is spending on this event were instead spent on searching for our children the way we search for them, [See Protests, A4]

Palisades fire painted as revenge plot

As arson trial begins, prosecutor accuses suspect of starting blaze with malicious intent. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

SpaceX poised for record IPO

The stock offering is expected to value the company at \$1.77 trillion. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 84/63. **B6**

Markets

Opinion Voices **A11**

An ovation just for Dudamel

L.A. Phil joins crowd in applauding its departing music director. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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